HOTS: If the Earth is not inclined at $23\frac{1}{2}^{o}$ angle, what would happen to the Earth?

4. Spheres of the Earth

The Earth is the most suitable planet to support life. It has three major components that we call as the realms of the Earth- lithosphere, hydrosphere and atmosphere. The three components along with suitable climate make life possible on Earth. All living things exist in a narrow zone called the biosphere. Now let us have a close look at each of the spheres.

Lithosphere

The word lithosphere is derived from the Greek word **Lithos**, which means rocky. The Lithosphere is the land on which we live. It is the solid outer layer of the Earth consisting of rocks and soil.

Hydrosphere

The word **Hydro** means water in Greek. The hydrosphere consists of water bodies such as oceans, seas, rivers, lakes, ice caps on mountains and water vapour in the atmosphere.

Atmosphere

The word **Atmo** means air in Greek. Atmosphere is the envelope of air that surrounds the Earth. Different types of gases make up the atmosphere. The major gases are Nitrogen (78%) and Oxygen (21%). The other gases like Carbon dioxide, Hydrogen, Helium, Argon and Ozone are present in meager amounts.

Biosphere

The narrow belt of interaction among the lithosphere, the hydrosphere and the atmosphere, where life exists is known as Biosphere. **Bio** means life in Greek. It consists of distinct zones. Each zone has its own climate, plant and animal life. These zones are known as ecosystems.



The Gulf of Mannar Biosphere Reserve in the Indian Ocean covers an area of 10,500 sq.km in the ocean.

Summary

- The Universe was formed 15 billion years after the Big Bang explosion
- Many galaxies are found in the Universe.
- Our solar system is a part of the Milky Way Galaxy.
- The Sun is so huge that it accounts for 99.8 percent of the entire mass of the solar system.
- All planets rotate anti-clockwise on their own axes except Venus and Uranus.
- Asteroids are found as a belt between Mars and Jupiter.
- The rotation of the Earth causes day and night.
- The revolution of the Earth causes seasons.
- Summer solstice is the longest day in the Northern Hemisphere.
- The presence of land, water and air along with suitable climate makes life possible on Earth.